than others, based on humanity's shared experience of that particular 'truth'. For instance, when we claim that a fruit tastes more 'acidic' than another, we rely on conventional standards based on our shared sense of taste—there is no 'ultimate truth' of the fruit tasting acidic outside the human mind.[31]

Nagarjuna's views have found strong resonance in recent Western philosophy, particularly that of the Austrian philosopher Ludwig Wittgenstein. Nagarjuna explained how we arrive at our most cherished beliefs, and how understanding this is conducive to a deep humility. In our own world of secular and religious strife—so often over 'truths' claimed to be objective or universal—his ideas emphasize the need to be always alert to context in our interaction with and judgement of others.

The Fall of Vijayapuri

The Ikshvaku Dynasty came to a sudden end around 310–20 CE, and Vijayapuri rapidly declined thereafter. Why? Most online material and mainstream history books call this a mystery. However, based on Longhurst's slim archaeological report in 1938 and ASI's very comprehensive report in 2006, two compelling theories, not mutually exclusive, seem plausible.

The first theory claims that the rising Pallavas invaded Vijayapuri from the south, defeated the Ikshvakus, and pillaged and wrecked the city so badly that it never recovered. Longhurst wrote, 'The ruthless manner in which all the buildings at Nagarjunakonda have been destroyed is simply appalling and cannot represent the work of treasure-seekers alone as so many of the pillars, statues and sculptures have been wantonly smashed to pieces.'[32] Many stupas, he continued, 'had been wantonly destroyed and many beautiful sculptures smashed to pieces'. Sculptural slabs had been 'thrown down in all directions and most of them purposely broken'. Perhaps the Pallava army also burned down the wooden superstructure above the stepped tank inside the citadel and the pavilion of the Sarvadeva temple, which we know were consumed by fire. Though the early Pallavas evidently had no affinity for Buddhism, it's quite likely that they had mostly political rather than religious motives. There is, however, no smoking gun